experience was akin to being under hypnosis. However, Bhavya Aggarwal from the California Hypnosis Institute, Noida, says it is not hypnotism but a game of psychological chessboard. It starts with a call from a stranger, using tone, empathy and familiarity to reel you in. Then comes the agency they are calling from—a courier company, Mumbai Customs—and a manufactured concern about your innocence. In the next stage, authority takes over. A "senior official", exuding power, enters the scene, their fake credentials convincing the victim that compliance is the only way forward. Trust builds; the victim's subconscious conflates authority with honesty, enough to hide it from their family. As scammers ramp up the pressure, the victim's brain enters what Aggarwal calls the "paradigm of translogic", where fear overwhelms rational thought. The amygdala, or the brain's emotional centre, floods with fear and information overload, hijacking the prefrontal cortex, the rational hub. Manipulation, not magic, is used to leverage trust and trap the victim by activating their survival instinct.

Educated professionals, says psychologist Dr Upasana Chaddha Vij of Mindscape Counselling Centre in Delhi, are wired to trust authority, and fear damage to their reputation. Fraudsters exploit this by flattering their targets, building camaraderie and preying on their need to protect their family. Jaipur-based psychologist Amitta Shringi highlights societal stigma as a key vulnerability, forcing victims into fight, flight or freeze—most succumb to freeze, complying to "end the trouble". It is this mental chaos that the scamsters exploit, confusing even the sharpest of minds.

THE WEB OF DECEPTION

Indian investigating agencies are slowly beginning to unravel the large international networks involved in these elaborate set-ups, acting in lockstep with Indian partners in crime. The masterminds, they believe, operate out of Southeast Asian bases; a significant presence of Chinese mafia, too, is suspected. The call centres and the detailed sets are primarily based in countries like Cambodia, Laos, Thailand and Myanmar, which have come to host bustling hubs for cybercrime in areas that lack robust law enforcement, have weak governance or where

JAIPUR

TANVI JAIN, 33

Manager, State Bank of India

The con: **Aadhaar tied to money-laundering**

Sum lost: **Rs 17 lakh** (since recovered)

"It was as if I was hypnotised"

It started with a call from a 'CBI officer' claiming that her SIM card had been linked to an illegal transaction at a Canara Bank account. Calm and professional, he suggested that Jain's Aadhaar might have been compromised during her recent hotel stays. "It's possible," the law graduate and company secretary admitted, unwittingly walking into the web. What followed was an eight-hour ordeal that almost cost her Rs 17 lakh, and left her questioning her own judgement.

The caller had promised all help. Slowly, the conversation even turned personal, with the man sharing anecdotes about his wife and her interest in investments. Jain found herself advising him on mutual funds, while revealing her own financial assets.

She was briefly suspicious when a 10-page 'Supreme Court document'—Tanvi Jain vs D.Y. Chandrachud—was sent to her. A law graduate, she knew such a case was improbable, but the caller's masterful control never allowed her doubts to take root. He said her Aadhaar was tied to a money-laundering case involving Naresh Goyal (founder of Jet Airways). There were also veiled threats. "I know how much money you've made," one of the fake officers shouted during a call, an accusation that brought her to tears. Earlier, another caller advised her to cry and beg if necessary. Their psychological manipulation was seamless—creating fear, then offering support, only to tighten their grip further.

The scammers didn't just demand compliance; they cloaked their fraud in layers of credibility. They made her instal Skype and staged walkie-talkie-like conversations with supposed investigators. They even advised her on cyber hygiene—warning her about leaving her Aadhaar or credit card with strangers and downloading unwanted apps.

"I know how much money you've made," one of the fake officers shouted during one of the calls. The accusation brought her to tears

Under their spell, Jain worked out the logistics of transferring Rs 17 lakh from her account. At the bank, when a junior officer questioned the urgency, Jain insisted it be processed quickly. She claimed she needed the funds for personal reasons, a lie she had been coached to tell.